

BUSA3021 PACE: Business Analytics Project

Professional practice: Data Analytics for Business Strategy

PREPARED BY GROUP TUTORIAL 1-5

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1. Introduction

Co-operatives are part of many areas of Australian life, including housing, childcare, agriculture, banking, and aged care. Despite this, they are often overlooked in discussions about how to address social and economic challenges. Mercury Co-operative's existing Co-op Map helps users locate co-operatives across Australia, but it mainly functions as a directory. This project expands the Co-op Map into an interactive visual exploration tool that helps stakeholders understand not only where co-operatives exist, but also where they may create the greatest community and strategic value.

Using Tableau, the project combines Mercury's co-operative directory with public datasets including ABS SEIFA, Modified Monash Model (MMM) classifications, aged-care service data, housing affordability data, and NSW social housing waitlist data. Bringing these datasets together allows the project to explore broader issues such as housing stress, rural service gaps, workforce challenges, and inclusive employment opportunities.

The project is structured around three stakeholder perspectives: Peter (Mercury Board Director), Min (MQ Employability Manager), and Sarah (Homes NSW Research and Investment Advisor). While each persona investigates a different challenge, all three explore the same central question: where can co-operative models help address unmet community needs and create long-term social value?

2. Design templates for three personas

2.1 Persona 1 — Board Director Peter

Persona 1	Board Director Peter
Role	A Board Director of Mercury Co-operative
Context of their work/role	Peter is a senior leader at Mercury Co-operative who is focused on creating long-term value for Mercury members and the broader co-operative ecosystem. He is interested in transforming the existing Co-op Map from a static directory into a strategic visual exploration environment that helps stakeholders better understand the Australian co-operative sector, identify collaboration opportunities, and explore future areas of growth and impact.

Key activities/ decision-making needs and interests	Peter is interested in understanding where co-operatives are concentrated, which sectors are most connected, and where communities may lack co-operative support. He also wants to identify opportunities for ecosystem-building, cross-sector collaboration, and future co-operative development in areas experiencing social or service gaps, particularly in rural and regional Australia.
DV Questions	Question 1: What does the current Co-op Map reveal about the structure, sector composition, and regional reach of Australia's co-operative ecosystem? Question 2: Where should Mercury prioritise ecosystem-building support by identifying co-operative concentration, spatial isolation, remoteness context and balanced collaboration potential? Question 3: Where are the specific geographic gaps left by exiting rural aged care providers, and how can co-operatives step in to fill these gaps using local ownership and shared services?

2.2 Persona 2 — MQ Employability Manager Min

Persona 2	MQ Employability Manager Min
Role	Leader of MQ Employability and Graduate Success
Context of their work/role	Min works within Macquarie University's Employability and Graduate Success team and is responsible for improving student employability outcomes, industry engagement, and graduate opportunities. Min is interested in exploring how the Australian co-operative sector could provide meaningful placement, employment, and entrepreneurial opportunities for MQ students, particularly for disadvantaged and underrepresented student groups.
Key activities/ decision-making needs and interests	Min is interested in identifying co-operatives with the capacity to host students, support PACE placements, and provide inclusive employment pathways. Min also wants to understand whether co-operative business models may offer stronger long-term sustainability for student-led ventures and social enterprises compared to traditional startup pathways.
DV Questions	Question 1: Does the co-operative sector in Greater Sydney have the capacity to host MQ students? Question 2: Do co-operatives serve the students who need support most? Question 3: Which industries show the co-op model outlasting traditional startups, and what does this mean for MQ's incubator?

2.3 Persona 3 — Research & Investment Advisor Sarah

Persona 3	Research & Investment Advisor Sarah
Role	Research & Investment Advisor, Homes NSW
Context of their work/role	Sarah works within Homes NSW and evaluates policy proposals and funding requests related to affordable and social housing. She receives submissions from organisations such as BCCM and ACHA advocating for greater investment in co-operative housing. Sarah requires evidence-based analysis to assess whether co-operative housing represents a viable long-term strategy for addressing housing affordability and social housing pressures in NSW.
Key activities/ decision-making needs and interests	Sarah is interested in understanding how Australia compares internationally in co-operative housing provision, whether existing co-operative housing is reaching communities experiencing the greatest housing stress, and whether co-operative housing models could provide scalable and sustainable alternatives to current market-led housing approaches.

Question 1: How does Australia's co-operative housing sector compare internationally, and what impact could co-operative housing have on long-term housing affordability?

DV Questions

Question 2: Are existing housing co-operatives reaching the communities that need them most?

Question 3: Can co-operative housing deliver on NSW's own housing commitments — and what would it take to scale them?

3. A sample of your resulting data sets

ID	post_title	Address	Suburb	State	Postcode	Latitude	Longitude	date_registered
10	10 post_title	113 Enmore Road Newtown 2042	Newtown	New South Wales	2042	-33.898502	151.174022	23/12/1988 Inner Villi
11	11 Afta House Community Food Co-op	The Cane Growers' Building 51 Richmond Street Warrle 2477	Warrle	New South Wales	2477	-28.95214	153.4666	18/4/1975 Ballina St
12	12 Back Channel Co-operative Limited	On Pacific Highway & Keppel Street Ballina 2478	Ballina	New South Wales	2478	-28.834761	153.563793	22/8/1945 Ballina St
13	13 Ballina Fishermen's Co-operative Ltd	51 Richmond Street Warrle 2477	Warrle	New South Wales	2477	-28.950784	153.4689	20/2/1974 Ballina St
14	14 Banks Estate Co-operative Limited	28 Queen Street Revesby 2212	Revesby	New South Wales	2212	-33.88688	151.200977	29/3/2018 Canterbury
15	15 Bankstown Canterbury Community Transport Co-operative Limited	Unit 63 753 Hume Highway Bass Hill 2197	Bass Hill	New South Wales	2197	-33.899484	150.993588	25/5/1977 Canterbury
16	16 Bankstown Family Day Care Co-operative Limited	11 East Terrace Bankstown 2200	Bankstown	New South Wales	2200	-33.913063	151.084894	27/6/1984 Canterbury
17	17 Bankstown Polish Club Co-operative Limited	5 McManus Place Lugarno 2210	Lugarno	New South Wales	2210	-33.985396	151.048461	21/6/1978 Georges I
18	18 Bankstown Steam Locomotive Society Co-operative Limited	53 Martin Place Sydney 2000	Sydney	New South Wales	2000	-33.867988	151.211087	23/2/1972 City of Syd
19	19 Barrington's Services Co-operative Limited	Unit 10 23 A Beckett Avenue Ashfield 2131	Ashfield	New South Wales	2131	-33.89087	151.123598	11/10/1978 Inner Wes
20	20 Barydigi Square Co-operative Limited	27 Beach Road Batemans Bay NSW 2536	Batemans Bay	New South Wales	2536	-35.713823	150.187672	9/4/1991 Eurobod
21	21 Batemans Bay Marina Co-operative Ltd	Shop 5 Macquarie Plaza 49 William Street Bathurst 2795	Bathurst	New South Wales	2795	-33.41643	149.58224	24/11/2010 Bathurst I
22	22 Bathurst Wholefood Co-operative Limited	Barlow Avenue Batlow 2730	Batlow	New South Wales	2730	-35.51937	148.142032	10/2/1984 Snowy Vi
23	23 Batlow Apple Tree Learning Centre Co-operative Ltd	31A Church Street Mayfield 2304	Mayfield	New South Wales	2304	-32.897035	151.741457	18/5/2010 City of Ne
24	24 Beanstalk Organic Food Co-operative Limited	137 Palmer Street Darlinghurst 2010	Darlinghurst	New South Wales	2010	-33.874832	151.217106	5/3/1971 City of Sy
25	25 Beehive Industries Co-operative Limited	212 Verona Road Verona 2550	Verona	New South Wales	2550	-36.468626	149.84222	11/12/2017 Bega Vall
26	26 Bega Beef Co-operative Limited	24 Millowine Lane Bega 2550	Bega	New South Wales	2550	-36.672154	149.849111	6/7/2012 Bega Vall
27	27 Bega Eco Neighbourhood Community Housing Co-op Ltd	101 Bega Street Bega 2550	Bega	New South Wales	2550	-36.671311	149.836404	12/5/1993 Bega Vall
28	28 Bega Valley Meals on Wheels Co-operative Ltd	52 Wharfside Street Bellingen 2454	Bellingen	New South Wales	2454	-30.445236	152.897399	7/1/1982 Bellingen
29	29 Bellingen Community Communications Co-operative Limited	16 Sunset Ridge Drive Bellingen 2454	Bellingen	New South Wales	2454	-30.446286	152.894853	5/8/1997 Bellingen
30	30 Bellingen River and Neighbourhood Housing Co-operative Ltd	17 Pamela Crescent Bowen Mountain 2753	Bowen Mountain	New South Wales	2753	-33.575444	150.62432	21/6/1985 Hawkesb
31	31 Belvedere Water Supply Co-op Limited	257 Loritos Access Dorrigo 2440	Dorrigo	New South Wales	2440	-31.136257	152.761045	18/8/1999 Kempsey
32	32 Beranghi Co-operative Limited	73-79 LAMONT STREET Bermagui 2546	Bermagui	New South Wales	2546	-36.427215	150.075762	10/4/1946 Bega Vall
33	33 Bermagui Fishermen's Co-operative Limited	27 Young Street Bermagui 2546	Bermagui	New South Wales	2546	-36.427829	150.078126	9/3/1978 Bega Vall
34	34 Bermagui Pre School Co-operative Society Limited	34 Lonsdale Avenue Berowra Heights 2082	Berowra Heights	New South Wales	2082	-33.609254	151.13943	21/7/2021 Hornsby I
35	35 Berowra Sustainability Co-op Ltd	204 Stoney Creek Road Bexley 2207	Bexley	New South Wales	2207	-33.948858	151.109308	28/4/2020 Bayside C
36	36 Bilingual Care Worker Co-operative of Australia Limited	50 Bulland Street Binnaway 2395	Binnaway	New South Wales	2395	-33.549742	149.379087	10/11/1972 Warrumb
37	37 Binnaway Bowling Club Co-op Ltd	6 New Line Road West Pennant Hills 2125	West Pennant Hills	New South Wales	2125	-33.740707	151.0479	18/5/1956 The Hills
38	38 Binnore Kindergarten Co-operative Society Limited	Unit 5 1 Carnegie Place Blacktown 2148	Blacktown	New South Wales	2148	-33.753842	150.903875	4/9/1953 Blacktown
39	39 Blacktown Masonic Hall Co-operative Limited	15 Gramma Street Blaxland 2774	Blaxland	New South Wales	2774	-33.746079	150.60927	10/3/1978 Blue Mts
40	40 Blue Mountains Railway Society Co-op. Ltd.	9 New Street Lawson 2783	Lawson	New South Wales	2783	-33.720563	150.429541	23/9/2013 Blue Mts
41	41 Blue Mountains Renewable Energy Co-operative Limited	1001 River Road Lower Portland 2756	Lower Portland	New South Wales	2756	-33.435133	150.903001	10/11/1980 The Hills
42	42 Bundell's Swamp Co-op. Ltd.	Baraduff Park Warners Avenue Bondi Beach 2026	Bondi Beach	New South Wales	2026	-33.88708	151.27563	9/11/1972 Waverley
43	43 Bondi Bowling Club Co-operative Ltd	55-59 Flood Street Leichhardt 2040	Leichhardt	New South Wales	2040	-33.882514	151.150036	30/12/1988 Inner Wei
44	44 Boom! Aboriginal Artists Co-operative Ltd	39 Bishop Street Boomi 2405	Boomi	New South Wales	2405	-28.723357	149.579546	3/1/2008 Moree Pia
45	45 Boom! Community Co-operative Limited	Boorowa Court House Marsden Street Boorowa 2586	Boorowa	New South Wales	2586	-34.4473	148.71255	4/1/1995 Hilltops C
46	46 Boorowa Court House Arts and Crafts Co-operative Ltd	Market Street Boorowa 2586	Boorowa	New South Wales	2586	-34.446991	148.716742	6/6/1972 Hilltops C
47	47 Boorowa Recreation Club Co-op. Soc. Ltd.	85 Kirkham Road Bowral 2576	Bowral	New South Wales	2576	-34.475184	150.418518	7/12/1926 Wingecan
48	48 Bowral Co-operative Limited	South Arm Road Bowralville 2449	Bowralville	New South Wales	2449	-30.658788	152.826815	21/11/1972 Nambecc
49	49 Bowralville Recreation Club Co-op Ltd	2000-2002 Creek Road Berrigalong 2574	Berrigalong	New South Wales	2574	-35.45147	149.89748	30/11/2012 Overland

4. Visual answers for three personas

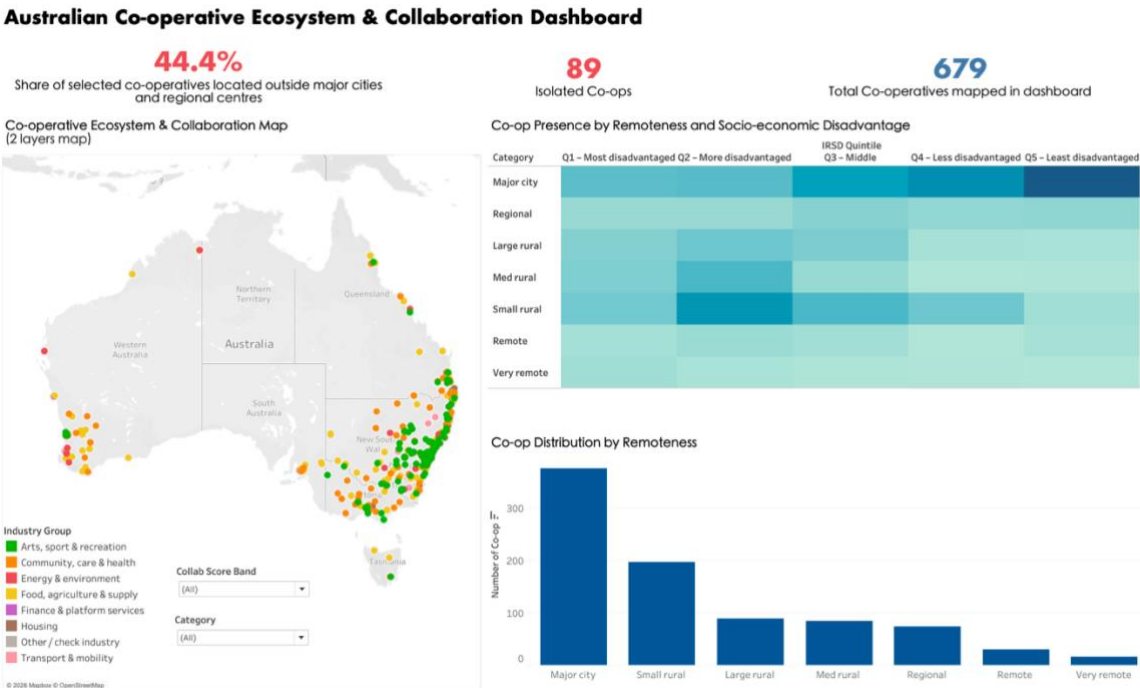
4.1 Persona 1: Peter | BOARD DIRECTOR, MERCURY CO-OPERATIVE

Mercury's Co-op Map is a valuable tool for identifying where co-operatives operate across Australia. However, for Peter and the Mercury Board, location data alone is not enough. To support strategic decision-making, the map needs to reveal how the co-operative ecosystem is structured, where collaboration opportunities exist, and where additional support may create the greatest value for communities.

The following analysis explores these questions in three stages. Question 1 examines the size, sector composition, and geographic reach of the ecosystem — establishing what exists and how far it extends. Question 2 then asks where co-operatives are positioned to collaborate, and where ecosystem-building support would have the greatest impact. Finally, Question 3 applies these findings to a real-world challenge — rural aged-care access.

4.1.1 Question 1: What does the current co-op map reveal about the structure, sector composition, and regional reach of australia's co-operative ecosystem?

Peter’s first challenge is not promoting co-operatives, but understanding the ecosystem itself. Before considering future investment or growth, he needs to know whether Australia’s co-operative ecosystem is **large enough, diverse enough, and geographically distributed enough** to support meaningful impact. Question 1 answers this by examining three structural dimensions: the size and composition of the sector, the sectors it spans, and how far its reach extends beyond major cities. Whether co-operatives located near one another are actually positioned to collaborate is a separate question, addressed in Question 2.



DEFINING THE ECOSYSTEM

Throughout this report, the **co-operative ecosystem** refers to the network of registered co-operative and mutual enterprises (CMEs) included in Mercury’s Co-op Map dataset — 679 organisations operating across sectors such as housing, aged care, food and agriculture, energy, retail, and community services. Where national figures are cited, they draw on the BCCM National Mutual Economy Report 2025 for broader context.

A. Where is the ecosystem already dense enough to support activation?

The **strongest geographic pattern is the concentration of co-operatives along Australia's eastern states**, particularly New South Wales and Victoria, with additional clusters across Western Australia, South Australia, and Tasmania. The Co-op Map captures 679 co-operatives across seven industry groups. The sector is not dominated by a single activity: **Arts, sport & recreation is the largest group (202 co-ops, 29.7%)**, followed closely by Community, care & health (25%) and Food, agriculture & supply (23.8%). Housing accounts for (10.7%), with smaller but strategically important presences in Energy & environment, Transport & mobility, and Finance & platform services. This spread matters because it shows the ecosystem is broad enough to support both within-sector peer learning and across-sector partnership.

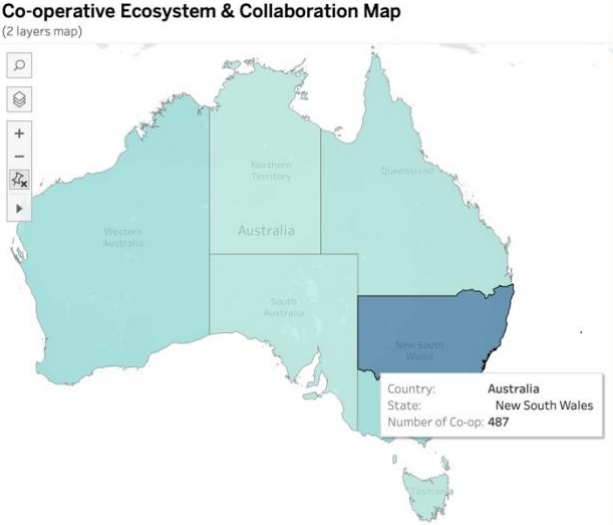


Figure 1. Geographic concentration of mapped co-operatives by Australian state and territory

Industry Group	Co-ops	% of total
Arts, sport & recreation	202	29.7%
Community, care & health	170	25.0%

Food, agriculture & supply	162	23.8%
Housing	73	10.7%
Energy & environment	27	4.0%
Transport & mobility	27	4.0%
Finance & platform services	19	2.8%

Table 1: Distribution of Co-operatives Across Remoteness Categories

Source: Mercury Co-operative dataset · Industry Group classification.

B. How far does the ecosystem reach beyond major cities?

One of the most important structural findings is that 44.4% of mapped co-operatives are located outside major cities and regional centres. While cities still contain the largest single share, the sector's presence across rural and remote Australia shows that co-operatives are not simply an urban phenomenon. The "Co-op Distribution by Remoteness" bar chart (Figure 2) confirms the gradient: Major City holds the largest count, followed by a long tail across Large rural, Medium rural, Small rural, Remote, and Very remote categories.

HOW 44.4% IS CALCULATED

The 44.4% figure refers to co-operatives in Modified Monash Model categories MM3 to MM7 — that is, Large rural town, Medium rural town, Small rural town, Remote community, and Very remote community. It excludes MM1 (Major City) and MM2 (Regional Centre). In other words, more than four in ten co-operatives sit beyond not only the major cities but also the regional centres.

This matters because regional co-operatives serve communities facing different conditions from metropolitan ones — larger distances, smaller local markets, and fewer nearby organisations or support services. For Mercury, a single, one-size-fits-all engagement model is therefore unlikely to work. Strategies built for dense metropolitan networks will need to be adapted for dispersed regional and rural realities — a theme Question 2 develops into specific support models.

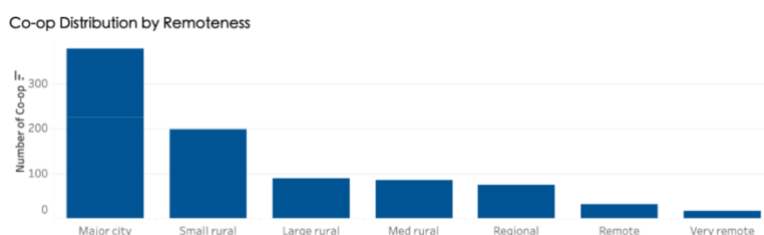


Figure 2: Distribution of Co-operatives Across Remoteness Categories

C. Does proximity predict collaboration?

Question 1 establishes three things the Board needs before any strategy discussion. First, the ecosystem is **substantial** — 679 organisations is a sector with genuine structural depth, not a directory of small clubs. Second, it is **sectorally diverse** — seven industry groups create the raw material for both peer-learning networks and cross-sector partnerships. Third, it is **geographically distributed** — with 44.4% beyond major cities and regional centres, the ecosystem reaches beyond major cities and regional centres, which makes the Co-op Map useful for understanding regional and rural co-operative presence rather than only metropolitan concentration.

These three facts frame the central question for Question 2: given that co-operatives exist across this range of sectors and places, where are they actually positioned to collaborate, and **where should Mercury focus its ecosystem-building support?**

4.1.2 Question 2: Where should Mercury prioritise ecosystem-building support by identifying co-operative concentration, spatial isolation, remoteness context and balanced collaboration potential?

Question 1 showed the ecosystem is large, diverse, and geographically distributed. Question 2 shifts from understanding the ecosystem to *acting* on it. For Mercury, the challenge is not to engage every co-operative in the same way — it is to identify where the conditions for collaboration already exist, and where a different kind of support is needed. Being located near other co-operatives is not the same as being positioned to collaborate with them; this question measures the difference.

DEFINITIONS — THE MEASURES USED IN THIS QUESTION

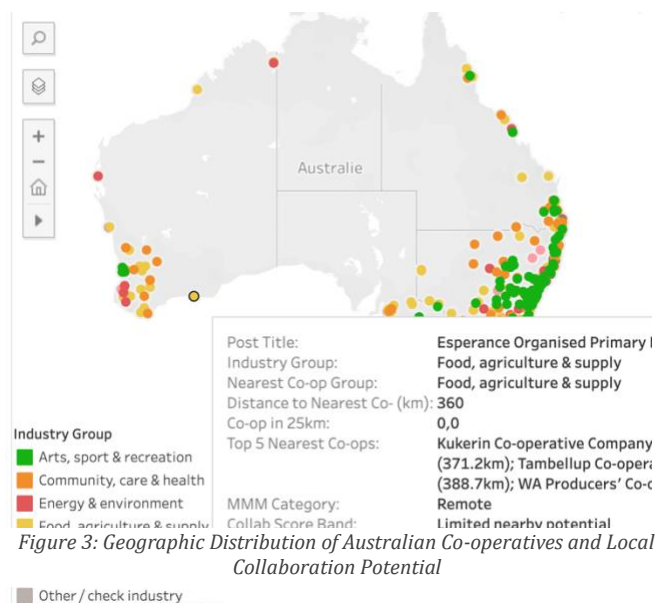
Balanced Collaboration Score (0–100): a composite screening score combining local density, same-sector peer potential, cross-sector potential, breadth of nearby sectors, and proximity. It is shown on the dashboard as the "Collab Score Band" filter, mapped as follows: High balanced potential (score ≥ 70), Moderate balanced (40–69), Limited nearby potential (1–39), and Not assessed (isolated co-ops with no neighbours within range). A high score signals favourable network conditions for facilitation — not that collaboration is already occurring.

MMM & IRSD: MMM is the Modified Monash Model, the Australian Government's classification of remoteness across seven categories from Major City (MM1) to Very Remote (MM7). IRSD is the ABS Index of Relative Socio-economic Disadvantage, where a lower score means greater disadvantage.

A. Where does ecosystem-building become actionable?

By scoring each co-operative's **Balanced Collaboration Potential**, the analysis separates the ecosystem into areas where collaboration conditions appear stronger and areas where a different support model is needed. Most mapped co-operatives operate in environments where collaboration may be easier — nearby co-operatives, opportunities to connect across sectors, and stronger local networks. A high score does not prove collaboration is ready to occur; it signals that the surrounding network conditions — density, sector complementarity, and proximity — make facilitation realistic. This acts as a **screening tool** for where Mercury should investigate first, allowing the Board to focus resources on environments that already have the ingredients for collaboration.

The dashboard reveals **64 high-diversity regional co-operatives** already surrounded by organisations from complementary sectors. In these areas, the conditions for collaboration already exist. The cross-sector pairings the data points to most clearly are: **care and housing co-operatives** around ageing-in-place and worker accommodation; **food and agriculture** co-operatives connecting with retail co-operatives to strengthen local supply chains; and **energy and environment** co-operatives linking with community housing to share infrastructure costs.



B. What do spatially isolated co-operatives reveal?

At the other end of the spectrum, **89 co-operatives are completely isolated**, with no other mapped co-operative within 25 km. This does not mean these organisations are struggling — in many cases they simply operate in regional and remote communities where there are few nearby organisations to collaborate with. The finding carries an important lesson: **not all co-operatives need the same type of support**. Traditional networking events and local collaboration programs have limited value when organisations are separated by large distances. These co-operatives may benefit more from online peer networks, virtual learning, shared back-office services, and regional partnerships that maintain connection without relying on physical proximity.

C. How do remoteness and socio-economic context define the priority gap?

When remoteness is crossed with socio-economic context, the dashboard shows that co-operative density varies across different operating environments. Major-city areas have the strongest visible concentration, while regional and rural areas show existing but more dispersed co-operative presence. Remote and very remote areas show the thinnest visible local density in the current dataset.

The strategic issue is not simply where co-operatives are located, but where the mapped ecosystem provides enough local presence for connection, peer support and shared-service opportunities to be realistic. In major-city areas, stronger density creates a clearer base for local activation. In regional and rural areas, co-operatives are present, but distance and lower density make relationship-building less automatic. In remote and very remote areas, limited visible density suggests that local network-building may not be the first viable pathway.

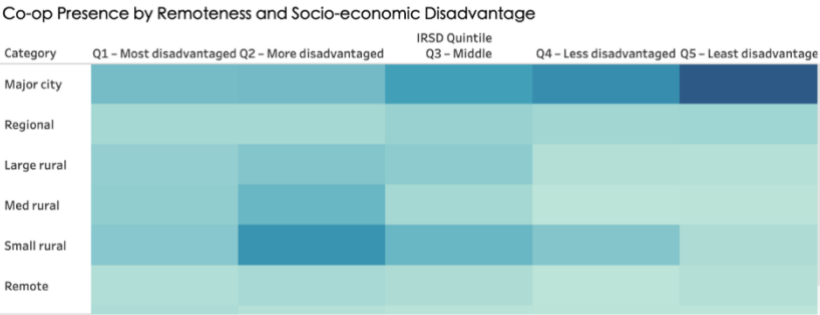


Figure 4: Comparing Co-operative Presence Across Community Need and Geographic

This means the MMM × IRSD view should be read as a context layer, not as a ranking of communities. It helps Mercury distinguish between places where existing density can support local engagement and places where ecosystem-building may need broader regional, digital or longer-term support models.

Three distinct strategic geographies emerge from the data, each with a different implication:

Major-city ecosystem — strong local base

High co-op count, closer proximity and stronger visible density create the clearest base for local ecosystem activation.

Regional and rural ecosystem — dispersed presence

Co-ops are already visible across regional and rural areas, but density is thinner and organisations are more spread out.

Remote and very remote ecosystem — limited local density

Few mapped co-ops are visible in remote and very remote areas, making local proximity-based connection less immediately practical.

Note on the IRSD data (data ethics): The heatmap identifies where co-operatives are operating in relation to community context. It does not characterise communities by their disadvantage. The index is used as a planning layer — to understand where ecosystem support would create the greatest community value — not as a label. Areas with fewer co-operatives or higher disadvantage should not be read negatively; such patterns may reflect historical investment, location, or gaps in the data rather than the strength or potential of a community.

D. Collaboration patterns and potential responses

The dashboard distinguishes four collaboration patterns, each calling for a different Mercury response. Together they convert the analysis into an operating model the Board can act on.

Table 2: How Mercury Can Respond to Different Collaboration Environments

Collaboration pattern	What the dashboard shows	Collaboration patterns and potential responses
Local ecosystem cluster	Many co-operatives within 25km	Facilitate introductions, networking events and shared-service conversations
Same-sector cluster	Multiple nearby co-ops, same industry	Support peer learning, benchmarking, joint advocacy, and shared procurement
Cross-sector cluster	Nearby co-ops from different industries	Explore partnerships such as care and housing, or food and retail
Isolated co-op	Zero co-ops within 25km	Provide digital networks, online peer learning, and shared support services

Source: Mercury Co-operative dataset · Collaboration Diversity Ratio methodology

E. What should Mercury do with these findings?

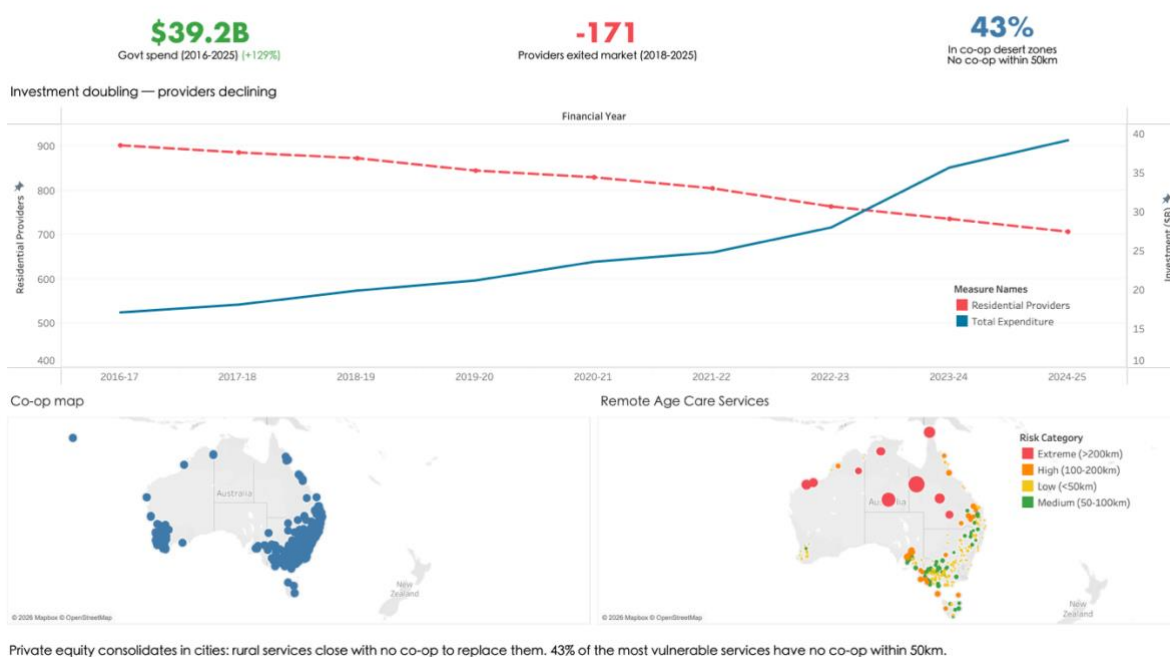
The findings suggest that **regional and rural communities should be a key focus for future ecosystem-building**. Many areas with the highest social and economic need also have the weakest co-operative networks; strengthening connections and exploring shared-service models there may create the greatest long-term impact. The **89 spatially isolated co-operatives** should not be overlooked because they are distant — they may benefit from digital peer networks, shared back-office services, and regional partnerships.

Finally, **distance should be interpreted differently in metropolitan and regional contexts**. While a 25 km radius is a useful starting point in urban areas, larger collaboration zones are more appropriate in rural and remote communities where organisations are naturally more dispersed. Recognising this difference will help Mercury design support models that reflect local realities — and sets up Question 3, which applies these collaboration findings to the specific, documented problem of rural aged-care access.

4.1.3 Question 3: Where are the specific geographic gaps left by exiting rural aged care providers, and how can co-operatives step in to fill these gaps using local ownership and shared services?

Q1 mapped where the co-operative ecosystem is and where collaboration potential lies. Q2 showed where that ecosystem is thinnest relative to community need. Q3 takes both findings and applies them to a specific, documented, real-world problem — because the most useful thing the Co-op Map can do for Peter is not describe the ecosystem in general terms. It is to show where the ecosystem could address a problem the commercial market is actively failing to solve. The problem is rural aged care.

Q3. Where are the gaps left by rural aged care providers — and are there co-operatives nearby to fill them?



Dashboard 2: Persona 1 - Question 3

A. The paradox: more investment, fewer providers

Australian Government investment in aged care reached \$39.2 billion in FY25, representing a substantial increase over the past decade. Over the same period, the number of residential aged-care providers declined from 807 in FY18 to 636 in FY25, a reduction of 171 providers. While funding has continued to grow, provider numbers have moved in the opposite direction, particularly affecting rural communities where service delivery is often more difficult and costly.

GOVERNMENT INVESTMENT — RISING

\$39.2B

FY25 aged care investment — up 9.6% on FY24. Record government commitment to the sector.

KPMG Aged Care Market Analysis 2026

RESIDENTIAL PROVIDERS — FALLING

807→636

Residential providers FY18 to FY25 — a 21% decline. No reversal in sight despite record funding.

KPMG Aged Care Market Analysis 2026

The dashboard highlights an important pattern within the aged-care sector. While government investment continues to increase, the number of residential aged-care providers continues to decline.

Four key challenges help explain why rural aged-care providers continue to exit despite rising government investment. **First**, many rural communities are simply too small to support financially sustainable aged-care services. KPMG (2023) describes these areas as "thin markets", where the number of potential clients is often too low to achieve viable scale. **Second**, workforce shortages are particularly severe in regional Australia. Research from La Trobe University (Morris et al., 2025) estimates that rural areas require approximately 95,000 additional full-time care workers to reach the same level of workforce coverage as metropolitan areas. **Third**, providers must meet the same regulatory requirements, including 24/7 registered nurse coverage and minimum care-minute standards, regardless of their size (Royal Commission, 2021). **Finally**, KPMG (2026) reports that the sector is becoming increasingly concentrated, with larger providers focusing on metropolitan markets while smaller providers continue to withdraw from rural communities.

Together, these challenges help explain why provider numbers continue to fall, even as government funding reaches record levels.

B. 43% of vulnerable rural services have no co-operative within 50km

The service gap map compares rural aged-care services with the location of existing co-operatives. The proximity categories — extreme (over 200 km), high (100–200 km), medium (50–100 km), and low (under 50 km) — show how close each service is to the nearest co-operative.

The 43% figure is derived as follows. The Mercury dataset identifies 261 residential aged-care services located in rural and remote areas (Modified Monash Model categories MM5–MM7). For each service, the distance to the nearest co-operative is calculated using all 679 mapped co-operatives across housing, care, food, energy, retail, and community services. A 50 km radius is used as the collaboration threshold for rural contexts, reflecting the larger service areas typically found outside metropolitan regions. The analysis shows that **111 of the 261 services (43%) have no co-operative of any kind within 50 km.**

This finding highlights a significant gap in the current ecosystem. Many rural communities facing aged-care challenges also have limited access to nearby co-operative organisations that could provide support, partnership opportunities, or local infrastructure. Rather than being a future risk, this is a gap that can already be observed in the data, helping identify communities where additional support and co-operative development may be most needed.

C. Can Co-operative Models Help Address These Gaps?

The findings suggest that co-operative models may offer an alternative approach in communities where traditional service delivery models face ongoing challenges. Unlike investor-owned organisations, co-operatives are owned and governed by the communities or members they serve, allowing decisions to be guided by local needs and long-term community outcomes.

One example is the **Care Together program**, delivered by the Business Council of Co-operatives and Mutuals and funded by the Australian Government Department of Health, Disability and Ageing. The program supports shared-services co-operatives that allow smaller providers to share functions such as compliance, finance, human resources, and administration. By reducing duplication and spreading costs across multiple organisations, providers can focus more resources on delivering care.

A leading example is the Murrumbidgee Aged Care Network, where five regional NSW providers formed a shared-services co-operative to pool back-office functions and improve long-term sustainability.

Building on these findings, the dashboard groups the 43% service gap into four opportunity zones, each representing a different starting point for future co-operative development and support.

Partnership zone

Rural aged-care service within 50km of an existing co-op. Co-operative infrastructure nearby — collaboration is geographically realistic. Mercury's platform can facilitate introductions now.

Shared-service zone

Local co-ops exist but not in aged care specifically. Workforce, transport, or community functions may be shareable across organisations — Care Together model directly applicable.

New development zone

No co-op within 50km. Thin market — new co-op formation is the longer-term pathway. Mercury's role here is formation support, not platform facilitation.

Care + housing opportunity zone

Aged-care gap overlaps with workforce accommodation pressure in the same community. A coordinated co-operative response across both sectors produces more than either intervention alone. Real examples include communities in the Riverina and Central West NSW.

Source: Mercury dataset · KPMG Aged Care Market Analysis 2026 · Care Together program · Australian Government Department of Health

D. Rural aged care is not only a care problem

The map reveals a connection that does not appear in single-sector analysis. Where aged-care access gaps and workforce accommodation pressures overlap in the same rural community, the two problems are reinforcing each other. Even where a care co-operative could be established, recruiting and retaining workers is difficult without affordable local housing. Workers cannot stay in communities where accommodation is scarce or unaffordable.

This means the care and housing opportunity zones identified in the dashboard represent something more than two separate problems in the same location. They are communities where a coordinated co-operative response across sectors — care and housing working together — would be more effective than either intervention alone.

Table 3: Rural Aged-Care Challenges and Potential Co-operative Responses

Problem in Rural Aged Care	Co-operative Response	Why It Works
Provider withdrawal or consolidation	Local community-owned care co-op	Does not exit when margins fall — owned by and accountable to the community it serves
High back-office and compliance burden	Shared-service model through Care Together	Pools administrative functions across multiple small providers — reduces cost without reducing accountability
Workforce attraction and retention	Link care co-ops with housing co-ops	Provides affordable worker accommodation — removes the housing barrier to rural workforce recruitment
Geographic isolation	Regional co-op network across multiple sites	Shares resources across a region rather than depending on a single viable site

E. What the data suggests

Three patterns emerge consistently across the evidence in Q1, Q2, and Q3.

The first is that the ecosystem is substantial and geographically distributed. 679 co-operatives mapped, 44.4% outside major cities. 64 high-diversity clusters where the conditions for collaboration already exist. The map is not a directory of small organisations. It is a picture of a significant sector with genuine structural depth.

The second is that the ecosystem is thinnest where community need is greatest. The MMM × IRSD data shows that rural and remote communities with the highest social and economic need have the least co-operative presence. The gap between where the ecosystem is and where it would create the most social value is visible and measurable.

The third is that the aged-care data makes that gap concrete. \$39.2 billion invested, 171 providers gone, 43% of vulnerable rural services without a co-operative within 50km. The Co-op Map can move from describing where co-operatives are to showing where they could address a problem the commercial market has structurally abandoned.

What those findings mean for how Mercury develops its platform, prioritises its programs, and makes the case to its board is a question for the people in the room with the authority to act on it.

4.2 Persona 2: Min | EMPLOYABILITY MANAGER, MACQUARIE UNIVERSITY

Macquarie University is welcoming more students from diverse backgrounds than ever before. However, increasing enrolments alone does not guarantee that students feel supported, connected, or confident when preparing for employment. For Min, the challenge is not simply finding more organisations willing to host students. The challenge is finding partners that can provide meaningful experiences, support student development, and help create pathways into long-term employment.

The following dashboards explore whether the co-operative sector can help address this challenge. The first identifies co-operatives with the strongest capacity to host students. The second examines how co-operatives focused on inclusion and community participation may help support disadvantaged students. The final dashboard explores a broader question: if co-operatives consistently survive longer than traditional startups, should MQ expose students to alternative business models earlier?



Leveraging the Australian Co-operative Sector for Macquarie Student Success

LGA

(All)

270

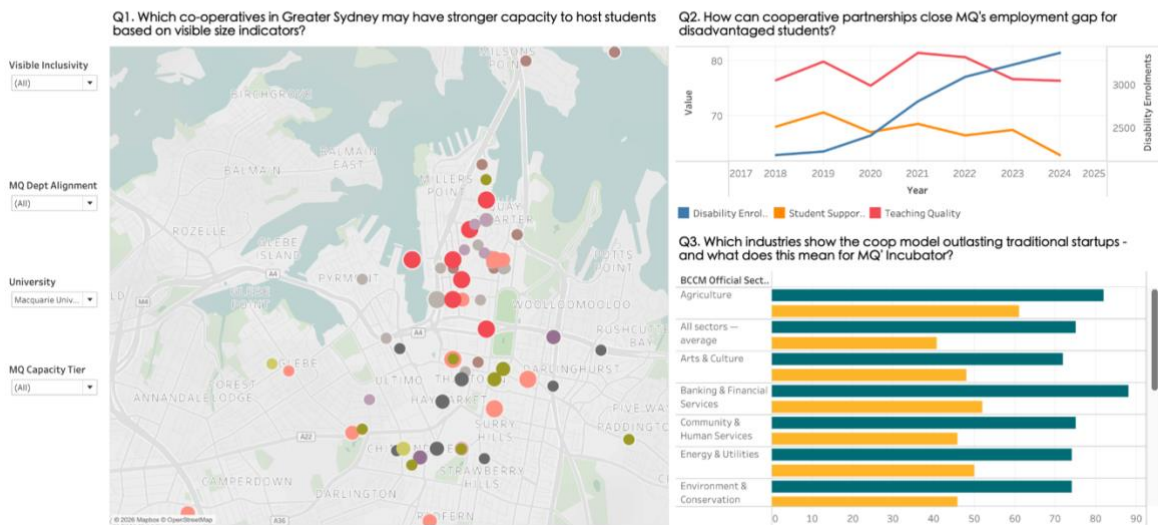
Coops Identified in Greater Syney

13.4%

higher full time job attainment rate if graduate with work-based placements

+58.04%

Co-op 5yr Survival Advantage Vs Startups (Avg across all Sectors)



Dashboard 3: Persona 2 - Question 1, 2 and 3

4.2.1 Question 1: Does the co-operative sector in Greater Sydney have the capacity to host Macquarie University students?

Before Min can build a placement strategy around co-operatives, she needs to answer the most basic question: is there actually enough there to work with? The size and maturity of the Greater Sydney co-operative ecosystem is the answer.

A. The sector is larger and more mature than expected

Greater Sydney has 270 active co-operatives spanning 15 sectors. The average organisation has been operating for 38 years. These are not new ventures or pilot programs. They are established organisations with governance structures, operational histories, and in many cases, existing relationships with community and workforce partners.

270

Active co-operatives in Greater Sydney across 15 sectors — larger than typically assumed

Mercury co-operative dataset · BCCM sector classifications

38 years

Average organisational age — established, not experimental

Mercury co-operative dataset

32

High-capacity, pitch-ready organisations — a focused starting point for Min

Mercury dataset capacity classification

The 38-year average is the number that reframes the conversation. Co-operatives are often assumed to be small, fragile, or community-focused in ways that make them unsuitable for professional placement pipelines. The data from Greater Sydney suggests something different — a sector with deep roots and demonstrated staying power.

B. Not all co-operatives are the same

270 co-operatives does not mean 270 placement opportunities. To give Min a usable starting point, the dataset was assessed against visible size indicators — organisational age, sector relevance, operational maturity, and evidence of active business or service activity — to produce a three-tier capacity classification.

Table 4: Capacity sector count of Greater New South Wales co-operative

Capacity tier	Count	% of total
High capacity	32	12%
Medium capacity	180	67%
Low capacity	58	21%

Only **32 organisations** meet the criteria for **high capacity**. This number changes the role of the co-op map from a directory into a decision-making tool. Rather than reaching out to hundreds of organisations with varying levels of readiness, Min has a defined group of 32 that already show the clearest signs of placement readiness. Medium-capacity organisations are not irrelevant — they may be well suited to smaller projects, one-off placements, or faculty-specific engagement as partnerships develop over time.

C. Where they are

Location matters for student placements. Most MQ students rely on public transport, which makes geographic accessibility a practical filter, not just a preference. The co-op map shows two clusters that are particularly relevant for MQ's student population.

CBD + Inner City

CITY OF SYDNEY · INNER WEST · NORTH SYDNEY

Accessible from Macquarie Park by train. Include a concentration of professional, business, and community service organisations aligning with MQ's high-enrolment faculties.

Western Sydney

PARRAMATTA · CUMBERLAND · FAIRFIELD

Particularly relevant for students from Western Sydney backgrounds who may benefit from placements closer to home. Aligns with MQ's widening participation goals.

D. Alignment with MQ faculties

The bar chart showing alignment between Greater Sydney co-operatives and MQ departments reveals that **MQBS has the highest alignment**, with the largest number of co-operatives mapping to business-relevant sectors. Management, Arts, and Health show moderate alignment. Science and Engineering has the lowest count, and those placements would require more investigation to confirm supervision and compliance suitability.

The sector alignment data points in a consistent direction: the co-operative ecosystem is deepest in the areas where MQ's student demand is also highest.

Q1 establishes that the sector exists, is mature, and has a defined subset ready for engagement. The next question is whether that subset serves the students Min is most focused on.

4.2.2 Question 2: Do co-operatives serve the students who need support most?

Knowing that 32 high-capacity co-operatives exist is a starting point. But Min's challenge is more specific than placement numbers. MQ is enrolling more students from disadvantaged backgrounds, and the data shows that support outcomes

have not kept pace with that growth. The question Q2 asks is whether co-operative placements could help close that gap — not just by providing work experience, but by providing the kind of environment where disadvantaged students are more likely to feel included and supported.

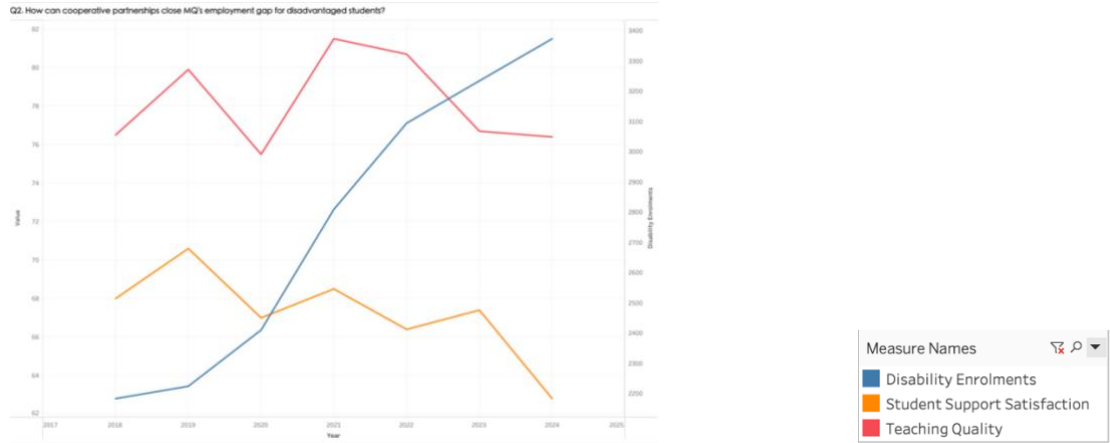


Figure 5: Macquarie University Student Support, Teaching Quality, and Disability Enrolments Over Time

A. The gap between enrolment and support

Between 2018 and 2024, disability enrolments at MQ increased by 54.5% — from 2,183 to 3,373 students. Over the same period, student support satisfaction fell from 68.0 to 62.8, placing MQ seventh out of eleven NSW universities and below the state average of 63.7. Teaching quality remained essentially stable at 76.4.

Metric	2018	2024	Change
Disability enrolments	2,183	3,373	+54.5%
Student support satisfaction	68.0	62.8	-7.6%
Teaching quality	76.5	76.4	-0.1%

Table 5: MQ Student Support, Teaching Quality, and Disability Enrolments change from 2018 to 2024

Source: QILT Student Experience Survey 2018–2024 · MQ institutional data

The pattern is clear. MQ is succeeding at widening access. The challenge now is whether students — particularly those from disadvantaged backgrounds — feel connected, supported, and confident enough to make the transition into employment. A placement environment that reinforces that confidence matters as much as the placement itself.

B. 64 inclusive co-operatives already exist across Greater Sydney

The map identifies **64 co-operatives across Greater Sydney** that are classified as inclusive — organisations specifically designed around disability employment, aged care, migrant support, housing, childcare, and community services. **Thirty-two of these are within 20km of MQ's Macquarie Park campus.**

LGA / area	Co-ops	Notable organisations
City of Sydney	9	Beehive Industries, Tenants' Union, Common Equity NSW
Inner West Council	8	The Social Outfit, Boomalli Arts, Ethnic Community Services
Canterbury-Bankstown	4	Bankstown Community Transport, Bankstown Family Day Care
Fairfield City	4	Kapit-Bahayan, Filipino Community Co-op, Lao Community Advancement
North Sydney / Ryde	3	SILC — 9.1 km from MQ, Australia Qing Yuan — 6.9 km
Parramatta / Cumberland	3	TaskABLE — 11.2 km from MQ, Australian Anatolian Community Services

Table 6: Greater Sydney Co-op Hotspots by LGA / Area

Source: Mercury dataset · BCCM sector classifications · Google Maps distance from Macquarie Park

What makes these organisations relevant is not just their proximity. Co-operatives are structurally different from typical corporate placement environments. They are built around participation, belonging, and community accountability rather than individual performance and competitive selection. For students who have experienced barriers to employment — whether through disability, cultural background, or limited professional networks — that structural difference matters.

C. Employability is about more than job titles

The broader insight from Q2 is that employability support for disadvantaged students is not only about securing a placement. **Confidence, belonging, and the experience of being genuinely** included in a professional environment are equally important parts of long-term employment success.

Co-operatives offer something that most placement providers do not — an environment where participation is the design principle, not an afterthought. The 64 inclusive co-operatives in Greater Sydney represent a placement pipeline that could address MQ's support satisfaction challenge at the same time as its placement capacity challenge.

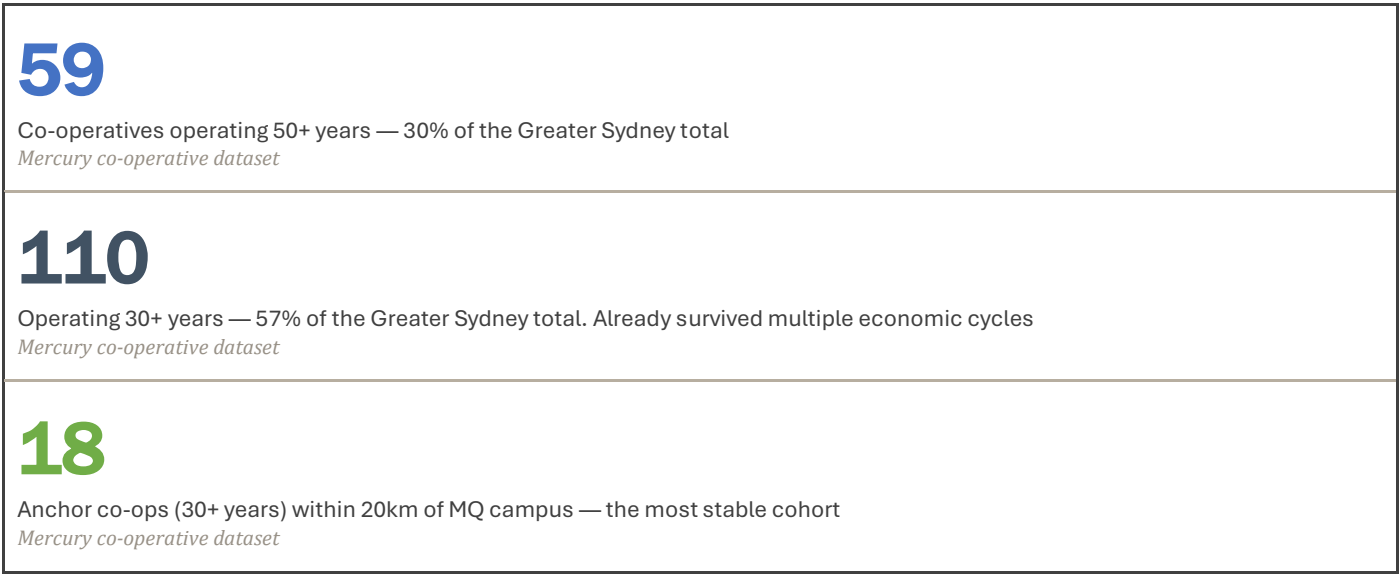
Q2 shows the sector is not just large enough — it is aligned with the students Min is most focused on. Q3 widens the lens: it asks not only whether these organisations are stable enough to be reliable long-term partners, but whether the co-operative model itself is something MQ's student founders should be learning from.

4.2.3 Question 3: Which industries show the co-op model outlasting traditional startups, and what does this mean for MQ's incubator?

Before MQ invests time and resources in building partnerships with any organisation, there is a practical question that rarely gets asked: how likely is this organisation to still exist in five years? For placement pipelines to work, the partners at the other end need to be stable. Q3 looks at what the data says about co-operative longevity — and what that means for Min.

A. The sector has already demonstrated survival

Of the co-operatives identified in Greater Sydney, 110 — 57% of the total — have been operating for at least 30 years. 59, or 30%, have been active for 50 years or more. The average age across all sectors is 38 years.



These are not projections. They are organisations that have already operated through multiple economic cycles, government funding changes, and market shifts. The longevity is observable in the data.

The pattern is not uniform across sectors. Education and Research co-operatives average 57.9 years. Social, Sports and Recreation average 51.8 years. Arts, Culture and Media average 31.8 years. Health, Aged Care and Childcare average 28 years. These are sectors where shared ownership, community trust, and long-term participation are central to how the organisation works — which is also why they tend to last.



ARTS, CULTURE + MEDIA

31.8

Average years operating

HEALTH, AGED CARE + CHILDCARE

28.0

Average years operating

Source: Mercury dataset · BCCM sector classifications

B. Co-operatives outlast traditional startups

The longevity data from Greater Sydney is consistent with findings from the broader research literature. The BCCM *Leading the Resilience* (2020) report found that the average age of Australia's top 50 CMEs is **82 years** — compared to 65 years for the ASX top 50. That is a 25 per cent longevity advantage, not a projection but an observable difference in current average ages.

The survival rate comparison in the dashboard shows co-operative five-year survival rates against traditional startup three-year survival rates across sectors. The comparison is deliberately conservative, with co-operatives held to a longer window, and they still show stronger persistence across every sector measured. The strongest advantages appear in sectors where community trust and stakeholder participation are central to the model.

Measure Names

Coop 5yr Survival Pct
Startup 3yr Survival Pct

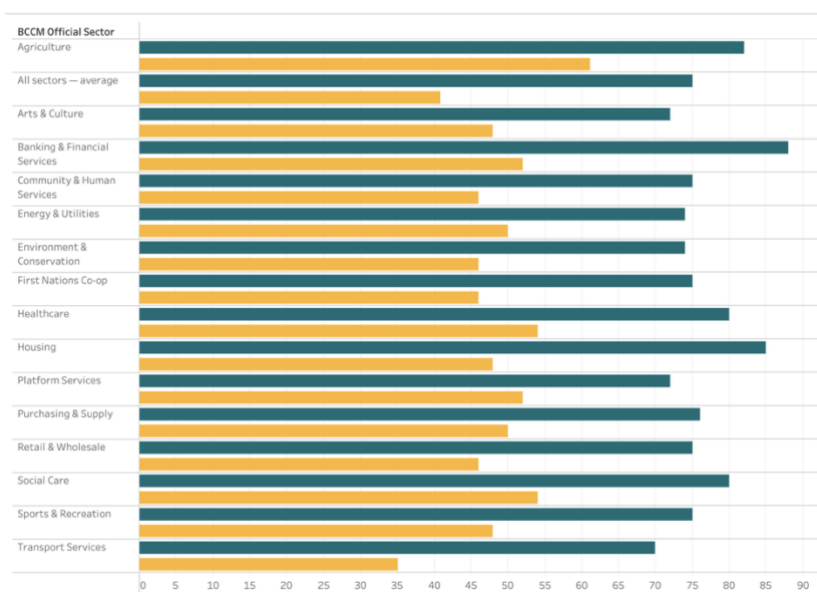


Figure 6: Co-op and Startup Survival Rates by Sector

LONGEVITY COMPARISON — CO-OPERATIVES VS ASX TOP 50

ASX TOP 50 — AVERAGE AGE

65 years

Average age of Australia's top 50 ASX-listed companies

CME TOP 50 — AVERAGE AGE

82 yrs

25% longer-lived — full 17-year advantage, observable today

Source: BCCM *Leading the Resilience Report 2020* · bccm.coop

A note on methodology: the sector-level survival rate figures in the dashboard draw on external benchmarks from the BCCM and NME literature, not on calculated survival rates from the Mercury dataset. The Mercury data provides corroborating age evidence. Both point in the same direction.

C. What this means for the incubator

Q3 raises a question that goes beyond placement pipelines. Most student founders at MQ default to registering a Pty Ltd company — it is familiar and assumed. But for ventures in health, education, community services, sustainability, and arts, the success of the organisation often depends not on investor returns but on **trust, participation, and long-term stakeholder commitment**. These are precisely the conditions where the co-operative model has shown structural advantages.

The 18 anchor co-operatives within 20km of campus — organisations aged 30 years or more — represent something concrete: living examples of the model that student founders could visit, speak with, and learn from directly.

Source: Mercury dataset · BCCM sector classifications

D. What the data suggests

Three patterns emerge consistently across the evidence in Q1, Q2, and Q3.

The **first** is that the sector is there. Greater Sydney has 270 co-operatives with an average age of 38 years. Thirty-two are high-capacity and placement-ready. Sixty-four are inclusive organisations aligned with MQ's widening participation student cohort. Eighteen anchor organisations sit within 20km of campus.

The **second** is that the sector serves the right students. The gap between MQ's growing disability enrolment and its declining support satisfaction is a real and measurable challenge. The inclusive co-operatives identified in Q2 are structured in ways that could address both the placement and the belonging dimensions of that challenge at the same time.

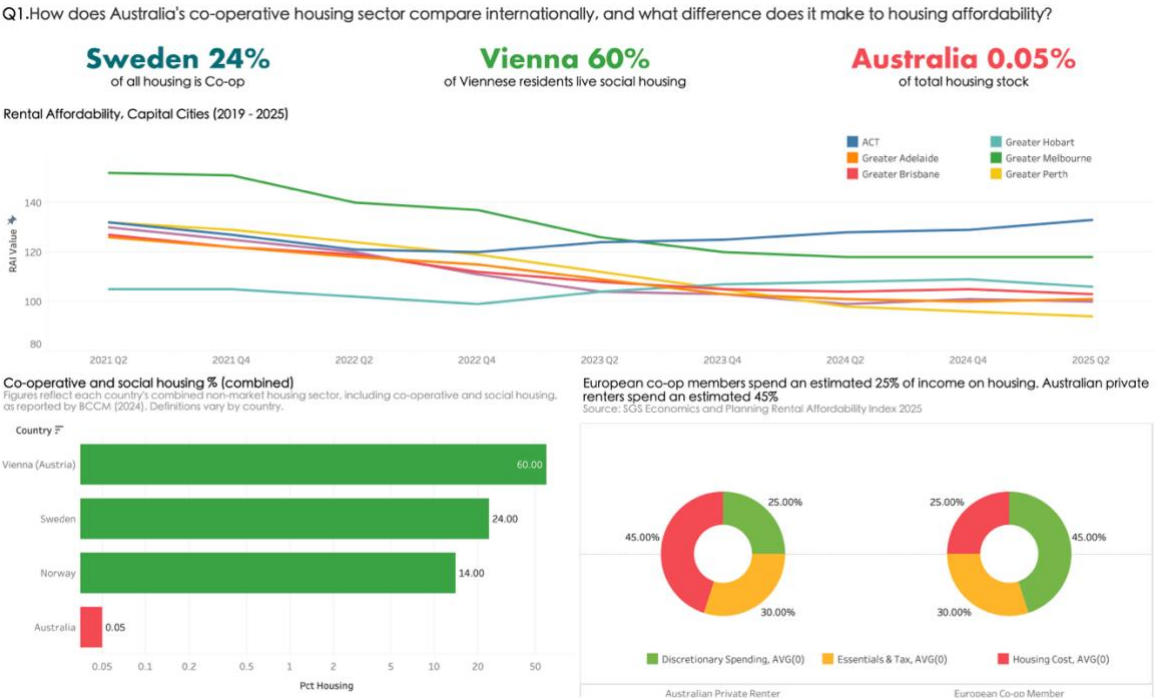
The **third** is that the co-op advantage is sharpest in specific sectors. Co-operatives outlast traditional startups across the board, but the gap is widest in health, education, community services and the arts, where trust and participation drive success. For MQ's incubator, that points to a clear move: founders building in those sectors should be shown the co-op model early, rather than defaulting to a Pty Ltd.

What those observations mean for how MQ builds its placement strategy, and how much weight the co-operative sector receives in that strategy, is a question for the people with the authority to decide it.

4.3 Persona 3: Sarah | RESEARCH & INVESTMENT ADVISOR, HOMES NSW

Sarah's role is not to advocate for co-operative housing. Her role is to assess whether the evidence is strong enough to justify government investment — and to answer the questions her colleagues and Treasury will ask. First: has this model actually worked? Second: does it fit the commitments the NSW Government has already made through Housing 2041?

4.3.1 Question 1: How does Australia's co-operative housing sector **compare internationally** — and what difference does it make to housing affordability?



Dashboard 4: Persona 3 - Question 1

The first question sets the foundation. Before Sarah can make the case for investment, she needs to answer the most basic challenge she will face: has this model actually worked anywhere? The international comparison answers that directly.

A. Australia is the outlier

Co-operative housing is not a niche experiment. In several comparable countries, it forms a major part of the housing system.

Country / City	What residents spend on housing
Vienna, Sweden, Norway	Within the internationally accepted affordability threshold of 30% of income
Australia	Above the 30% stress threshold in most capital cities — and declining

Table 7: Comparing Housing Affordability in Vienna and Australia

Figures reflect each country's non-market housing sector, including co-operative and social housing. Definitions and tenure structures vary by country. Australian housing cost figure based on SGS Economics and Planning Rental Affordability Index 2025 methodology. Sources: Grimstad, Seaborn and Taylor (2024) BCCM European Study Tour · SGS Economics and Planning Rental Affordability Index 2025

Australia's 0.05% means that for most Australian renters, the private market is the only option available. When rents rise, there is almost nowhere else to go.

The income figures in the pie chart show what that means in practice. In countries where co-operative housing is part of the system, residents typically spend around 25% of their income on housing — within the internationally accepted affordability threshold. Australian private renters spend an estimated 45%, based on SGS Economics and Planning's Rental Affordability Index methodology. That gap is not a minor statistical variation. It is the difference between a household with room to save, and one spending nearly half its income on housing before anything else.

Source: SGS Economics and Planning Rental Affordability Index 2025 · sgsep.com.au

B. Rental affordability has been declining across Australian cities

The SGS Economics and Planning Rental Affordability Index tracks affordability across Australian cities over time. A score at or below 100 means the average renting household in that area spends 30% or more of their income on rent — the formal definition of housing stress.

City	RAI Score	Status
Greater Perth	94	Below stress threshold

Greater Sydney	100	At stress threshold
Greater Adelaide	101	Near threshold — declining
Greater Brisbane	103	Near threshold — declining
Greater Melbourne	~108	Declining
ACT	~130	Most stable of all capital cities

Table 8: Rental Affordability Index (RAI) Scores Across Major Australian Cities (June 2025)

Perth has already crossed the threshold. Sydney sits exactly on it. Adelaide and Brisbane are close behind. Every city except the ACT has seen its score decline since 2021. The ACT, which has the most stable trend, also has the second-highest rate of co-operative housing per capita in Australia — a data point Q3 returns to.

Source: SGS Economics and Planning Rental Affordability Index 2025 · sgsep.com.au

C. One number to set the scale

28% of renting households nationally spend more than 30% of their income on housing. They are in housing stress — and most of them have no access to social or co-operative housing. They are entirely reliant on the private market.

That is the population Q2 looks at more closely.

Source: Australian Institute of Health and Welfare Housing Assistance in Australia 2024 · aihw.gov.au

D. What Q1 establishes for Sarah

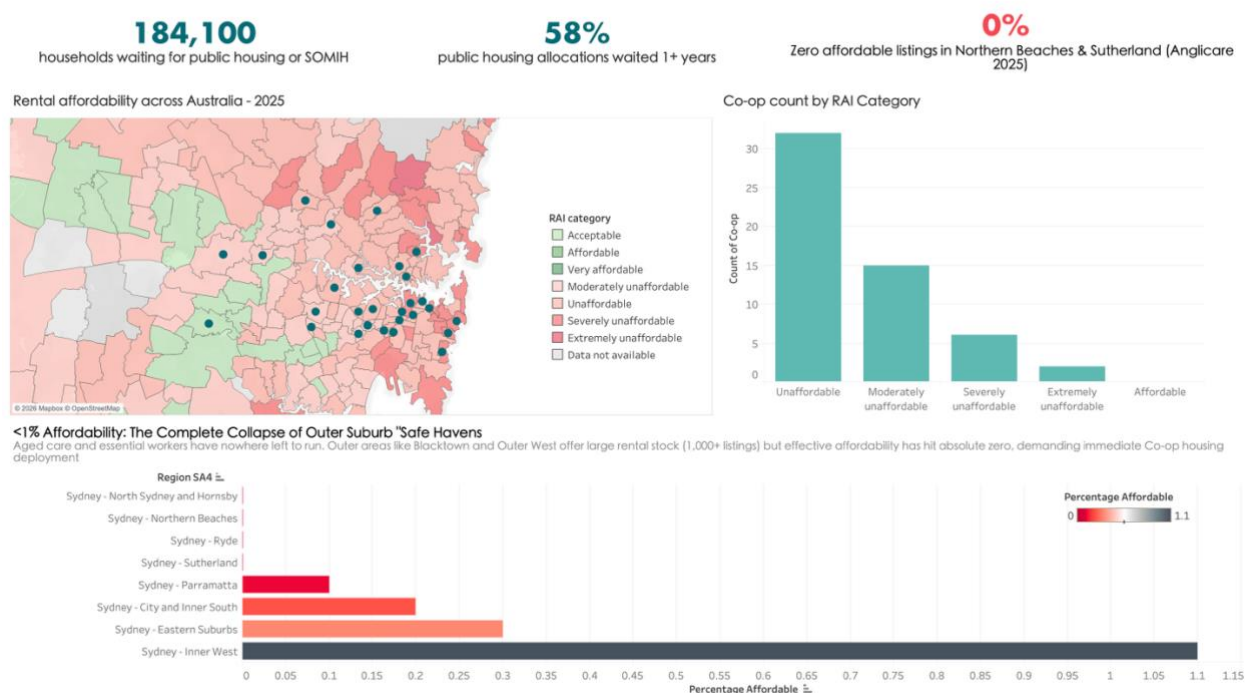
The international data does something specific for Sarah's internal case. It shows that Australia's affordability situation is not simply the result of market forces that no policy can change. Countries comparable to Australia — similar economies, similar population pressures — made sustained investments in non-market housing and produced measurably better affordability outcomes over time.

The countries that invested in co-operative housing built systems where residents spend 25% of their income on housing. Australia's private renters spend 45%. That difference is the foundation of Sarah's case.

Australia's co-operative housing sector is small — but it exists. Q2 looks at where it is today, who it is serving, and where the data points to next.

4.3.1 Question 2: Are existing housing co-operatives reaching the communities that need them most?

Q2. Are existing housing co-ops reaching the communities that need them most?



Dashboard 5: Persona 3 - Question 2

Q1 showed that co-operative housing works at scale internationally, and that Australia has very little of it. Q2 looks at what exists today — where co-operatives are located, who they are currently serving, and where the gaps remain. The answer shapes not just whether to invest, but where that investment would matter most.

A. The need is already large

Before looking at where co-operatives are, it helps to understand the scale of unmet need they exist within.

184,100 Australian households are currently on the waitlist for public housing or State-Owned and Managed Indigenous Housing. These are households that have already sought help from the system. 58% of public housing allocations in the most recent reporting period involved people who had been waiting for more than one year.

Behind that waitlist is a much larger group: the 28% of renting households nationally who spend more than 30% of their income on housing. They are in housing stress, but outside the system entirely. These are the people the private market is not serving — and the people co-operative housing was built to reach.

Source: Australian Institute of Health and Welfare Housing Assistance in Australia 2024 · aihw.gov.au

B. The Map: Where Co-operatives are today

The rental affordability map places two datasets side by side: the SGS Economics and Planning Rental Affordability Index 2025, which colours every postcode in Australia by affordability, and the location of existing housing co-operatives, shown as dots.

The map shows that co-operatives are concentrated in inner and inner-middle Sydney — areas that are already classified as unaffordable to moderately unaffordable. This is consistent with what co-operatives were designed to do: provide stable, cost-based housing in areas where private rents are high. The sector is doing what it was built for.

The map also shows something else. Surrounding those areas, and stretching outward into the northern beaches, the south, and outer west, the colours deepen to dark red — the most unaffordable categories. These are areas where the average renting household spends well above 30% of their income on rent. Co-operative housing dots are sparse or absent in these areas.

Source: SGS Economics and Planning Rental Affordability Index 2025

C. The numbers behind the map

The co-op count by RAI category chart puts precise numbers to what the map shows.

RAI Category	Co-op count	What this shows
Unaffordable	32	The largest concentration — co-ops present and active
Moderately unaffordable	15	Second largest — sector reaching into stressed areas
Severely unaffordable	6	Limited presence
Extremely unaffordable	2	Very limited presence
Affordable	0	Minimal — as expected

Table 9: Distribution of Housing Co-operatives Across Rental Affordability Categories

The majority of co-operatives are in unaffordable and moderately unaffordable areas. Only two are in areas classified as extremely unaffordable — the areas where housing costs are highest relative to income.

Source: SGS RAI 2025 · Seaborn (2024) BCCM

D. Where the gap is most visible

Across Greater Sydney, just one% of all rental listings examined by Anglicare NSW in March 2025 were affordable to essential workers. That figure — already very low — is not evenly distributed across the city.

The regional breakdown chart shows the percentage of affordable listings by Sydney area. Most regions sit well below one%. Two regions — Northern Beaches and Sutherland — recorded zero affordable listings across 17,028 listings examined on 15 and 16 March 2025.

These are not peripheral areas. Northern Beaches and Sutherland are home to major hospitals, aged care facilities, and health infrastructure. The workers who staff those services cannot find a single affordable rental listing in the areas where they work. And as the map shows, these are also areas with no co-operative housing presence.

Source: Anglicare NSW Essential Workers Housing Report 2025

E. Michael — and 3,000 others like him

Michael is a healthcare worker. He commutes one and a half hours each way, on two buses and a train, from outer western Sydney to the hospital where he works. He does not live far away by choice. He lives far away because there is nothing affordable near where he works.

His situation is not unusual. Research conducted for HOPE Housing found that essential workers across Greater Sydney are being pushed further from their workplaces as housing costs rise — with areas that were affordable in 2016 now out of reach for most essential workers. A separate HOPE Housing survey of 3,000 essential workers conducted in 2024 found that 56% were considering leaving their profession because of housing costs. These are the people who staff Sydney's hospitals, schools, and emergency services.

The data from Q2 points in a consistent direction: the need is large, it is concentrated in specific areas, and those areas have room for more co-operative housing. The question Q3 answers is whether co-operative housing — given what it is and how it works — is the right tool to respond to that need.

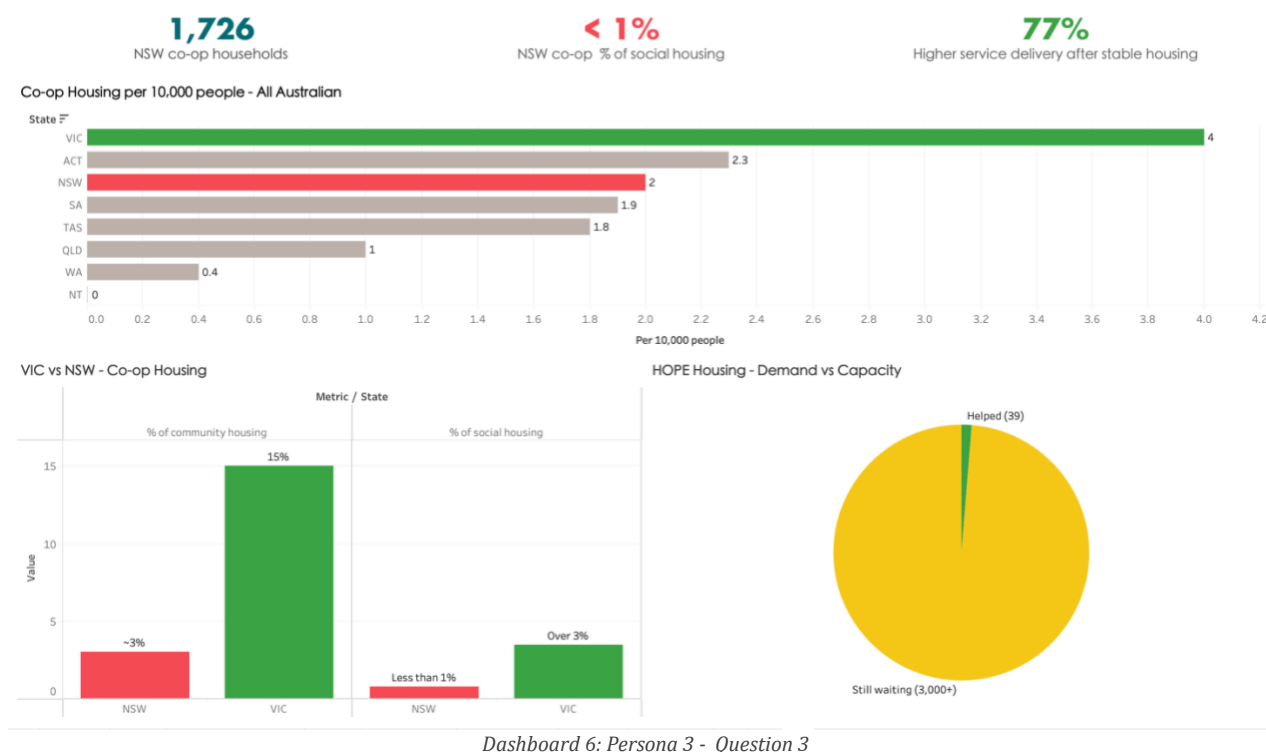
Source: Gilbert, C., Nasreen, Z., & Gurran, N. (2023) for HOPE Housing — commute patterns and housing stress among essential workers · HOPE Housing survey of 3,000 essential workers (2024) — 56% considering leaving profession

4.3.3 Question 3: Can co-operative housing deliver on NSW's own housing commitments — and what would it take to scale them?

Q1 established that co-operative housing works internationally and that Australia is significantly behind comparable countries. Q2 showed that the co-operatives that do exist in New South Wales are not where the crisis is deepest, and named the essential workers — people like Michael — who are paying the price for that gap. Q3 asks the question that Sarah needs to answer before she can walk into any government meeting: does co-operative housing fit what New South Wales has already committed to? And is there evidence that it can be scaled?

The answer to both questions is yes. But the evidence matters as much as the conclusion.

Q3. Can co-op housing deliver on NSW's housing commitments?



Dashboard 6: Persona 3 - Question 3

A. The Framework: Housing 2041

In March 2021, the NSW Government published Housing 2041 — a twenty-year housing strategy built around four pillars: Supply, Diversity, Affordability, and Resilience. This is the framework that Sarah is accountable to. The most direct way to make the investment case for co-operative housing is to test it against these four commitments directly, pillar by pillar.

Crucially, the NSW Government named co-operative housing in Housing 2041 itself. Page 17 states:

"Some people may own part of a home or be part of a cooperative that owns a home. This shows that Housing 2041 must consider all types and tenures to meet the changing nature of how we want to live in NSW over the next 20 years."

Page 33 goes further, listing new communal living models — including co-operatives — as approaches the government intends to encourage. This is not an external advocacy document making a case for co-operatives. It is the NSW Government's own strategy acknowledging that co-operative housing must be part of the answer.

Source: NSW Department of Planning, Industry and Environment (2021) Housing 2041 · p.17 and p.33

B. Testing against the four pillars

Pillar 1: Supply — Not Claimed

Housing 2041 defines supply as delivering the right number of homes in the right locations at the right time. New South Wales needs 30,000 to 40,000 new homes per year to keep pace with population growth.

At present, New South Wales has 1,726 co-operative housing households. This is not a meaningful contribution to housing supply at current scale, and this report makes no claim that it is. The case for co-operative housing rests on the kind of housing it provides and the communities it reaches — not on volume. Acknowledging this limit upfront protects the credibility of the three pillars that follow.

Pillar 2: Diversity — Strong Match

Housing 2041 defines diversity as providing a genuine range of housing types and tenures that reflect varied household needs — including, explicitly, essential workers in hard-to-fill locations and culturally appropriate housing for Aboriginal communities.

Co-operative housing is a fundamentally distinct tenure. It is not private rental, where a landlord sets market prices and a tenant has limited security. It is not home ownership, which requires substantial upfront capital. And it is not social housing, which is means-tested and rationed. It fills the gap between all of these — member-governed, cost-based, and permanent. This gap is real and is currently being filled by nothing else in the NSW housing system.

New South Wales already has working examples of co-operatives serving communities that no other housing model reaches. The BCCM's January 2025 submission to Homes NSW names five: Lac Viet Housing Co-operative for Vietnamese migrants; Tamil Senior Citizens Housing Co-operative for Tamil older adults; Alpha Artists House for artists; Stucco Co-operative for University of Sydney students in Newtown; and All Nations Housing Co-operative for the trans community. Five entirely different communities, all housed under the same co-operative structure.

The same submission identifies five Aboriginal housing co-operatives in New South Wales: Nungera, Ngemba, Illaroo, Ngalawi, and Bunjum. About four% of Aboriginal community housing in Australia is delivered through co-operatives — a model that aligns with the principles of community self-determination that Housing 2041 also commits to.

Source: BCCM Submission to Homes NSW January 2025 · p.4 and p.6 · Housing 2041 p.17 and p.33

Pillar 3: Affordability — Confirmed

Housing 2041 defines affordability as ensuring housing costs do not exceed 30% of gross household income. Q1 already established that co-operative housing members in comparable international systems spend around 25% of their income on housing. Q3 adds the structural explanation for why.

Co-operative housing achieves affordability through its mechanism, not through subsidy. Rents are set at the level needed to cover operating costs — maintenance, management, and loan repayments where applicable. They are not set to maximise returns to outside investors, because in a co-operative, the residents are the owners, and their interest is in stable, affordable housing rather than capital appreciation. This means co-op rents are structurally and permanently lower than market rents and do not drift upward when surrounding property values rise.

The BCCM's January 2025 submission describes an additional self-reinforcing mechanism: as a member's income rises, their rent rises proportionally, subsidising lower-income members in the same co-operative. When the higher-earning member retires and their income falls, their rent falls with it. Any surpluses generated during higher-income periods are used to build or purchase additional housing, growing the co-operative's stock without external capital.

Source: BCCM Submission to Homes NSW January 2025 · p.5 · Housing 2041 p.22 · SGS RAI 2025

Pillar 4: Resilience — Confirmed

Housing 2041 defines resilience as housing that endures through economic and social change — housing that is not destabilised by market cycles, investor exits, or funding changes.

The strongest evidence for co-operative housing's resilience comes from an independent, peer-reviewed research project. The Value of Housing Co-operatives in Australia, published in 2024 by researchers from Western Sydney University, Swinburne University, the University of Newcastle, and Griffith University, was funded by the Australian Research Council and took five years to complete. It produced the first national dataset on affordable rental housing co-operatives across four states.

Its findings were unambiguous: co-operative housing members experience higher levels of housing stability, quality, and security than people in all other forms of rental housing. They also demonstrate stronger community connections and higher levels of agency over their housing situation. The research found that co-op housing reduces costs because members actively participate in property management, reducing administrative and maintenance overheads.

The structural basis for this resilience is permanent tenure. A member of a housing co-operative cannot be evicted because a fund has reached the end of its investment horizon. They cannot lose their home because an investor decided to sell. Their rent cannot double because the market has moved. There is no expiry date. This is the direct opposite of the fund-cycle model used by shared-equity programs like HOPE Housing, which depends on investor appetite and has a defined investment horizon.

Source: Crabtree-Hayes, L. et al. (2024) The Value of Housing Co-operatives in Australia · WSU / ARC · doi:10.26183/0xpp-g320 · CEHL cehl.com.au

Supply

Housing 2041 identifies housing supply as a major priority, with NSW needing 30,000–40,000 new homes each year.

Housing co-operatives currently account for only around 1,726 households across NSW, making the sector too small to significantly increase housing supply on its own.

✗ NOT CLAIMED — HONEST

Diversity ✓

Housing co-operatives provide an alternative to private renting, home ownership, and public housing. Housing 2041 specifically recognises co-operatives as part of a diverse housing system.

Existing NSW co-operatives support a wide range of communities, including students, migrants, artists, older residents, transgender communities, and First Nations groups.

✓ SUPPORTS HOUSING 2041'S DIVERSITY GOAL

Affordability ✓

Housing co-operatives focus on keeping housing costs affordable rather than maximising profit.

Question 1 showed that co-op residents in Europe spend around 25% of income on housing, compared with around 45% for Australian renters. This is possible because rents are based on operating costs rather than market prices.

✓ IMPROVES AFFORDABILITY

Resilience ✓

Housing co-operatives provide long-term housing stability.

Research from ARC and Western Sydney University found that co-op residents experience higher housing stability than other renters. Organisations such as CEHL have operated since 1986 through recessions, housing downturns, and COVID-19, demonstrating the long-term resilience of the model.

✓ IMPROVES HOUSING STABILITY

Co-operative housing credibly meets three of the four pillars NSW has committed to. Supply is the honest exception. Three pillars is enough to justify the next question: why is this model not receiving investment?

C. Victoria already answered: The model can scale

A model that passes three policy pillars on paper is only useful if it can be delivered at scale in practice. The most direct answer to that question does not require looking overseas. It requires looking at the state next door.

Victoria and New South Wales started from the same point. Both states received Commonwealth funding in the 1980s. Both had small co-operative housing sectors at the time. Today, the difference between them is substantial.

Victoria — 40 years investing

4.0

Co-op households per 10,000 people

15%

Of community housing stock

Over 3%

Of social housing stock

\$860M

Budget 2026/27 Social Housing Growth Fund

NSW — strategy without investment

2.0

Co-op households per 10,000 people

~3%

Of community housing stock

<1%

Of social housing stock

1996

Last equivalent co-op investment program

Source: BCCM Submission to Homes NSW January 2025 · p.5 — published directly · Victorian Premier's Office Budget 2026/27 April 2026

New South Wales has approximately 1.5 million more people than Victoria, yet has half the co-operative housing per capita. The gap is not geography, demographics, or market conditions. It is three specific decisions that Victoria made and New South Wales did not.

- In 1983, Victoria legislated the Housing Act, embedding the funding relationship between the state government and the co-operative sector into law.
- In 1986, Victoria established Common Equity Housing Limited — a permanent institution to own properties, support co-operatives, and grow the sector over time.
- In 1996, when the Commonwealth Government cut national funding, Victoria had CEHL to fall back on. New South Wales had no equivalent infrastructure. The NSW sector stagnated. Victoria's continued.

The gap between Victoria at 4.0 co-operative households per ten thousand people and New South Wales at 2.0 is thirty years of compounding policy decisions. It is also the clearest possible evidence that the model can scale — because it already has, in the same country, under the same laws, using the same model.

Source: CEHL cehl.com.au · *Housing Act 1983 (Vic)* · ABS population June 2024

D. HOPE Housing has proved the demand is real

The final piece of evidence Sarah needs is proof that demand for alternative housing exists in New South Wales right now — not as a projection, but as a documented reality.

HOPE Housing launched in November 2022 in partnership with Police Bank, offering essential workers in Greater Sydney a shared-equity pathway to home ownership. In the three years since launch, thirty-nine essential workers have purchased homes through the program. Over three thousand are currently on HOPE's waitlist. That is 98.7% of demonstrated demand going unmet.

39 Workers helped in 3 years — 26 homes, Greater Sydney HOPE 2025 Impact Report	3,000+ On waitlist — 98.7% of demand unmet HOPE 2025 Impact Report
56% Considering leaving profession due to housing costs HOPE survey 2024	77% Report higher service delivery after stable housing Police Bank / HOPE July 2024

HOPE Housing is not a failed model. It is a purpose-built model for a specific market segment — and within that segment it works well. The structural limitation is that HOPE requires high property values to generate the investor returns that fund the program. It can only operate in areas where properties are expensive, and it requires workers to have sufficient income to service a mortgage. Workers who cannot afford to buy, workers in outer suburbs or regional areas, and First Nations communities are outside HOPE's reach by design.

Housing 2041 Goal	What HOPE Housing Shows	What Co-op Housing Can Offer
Essential workers near workplace	39 workers housed in 3 years	Designed specifically for affordable housing
Outer suburbs + regional NSW	Mainly Greater Sydney focus	Can be established in any LGA
Workforce retention	56% considered leaving due to housing costs	Stable, affordable housing supports workforce retention
Improved community outcomes	77% reported better service delivery after securing housing	Stable housing strengthens community participation
Long-term affordability	Partial solution through shared equity	Permanent affordability through member ownership
Scalable impact	39 homes delivered, 3,000+ on waitlist	Proven large-scale examples in Victoria and overseas

Table 10: Comparing Housing 2041 Objectives, HOPE Housing, and Co-operative Housing Models

Source: HOPE Housing website · hopehousing.com.au · BCCM Seaborn (2024) · Housing 2041 p.25

HOPE and co-operative housing are not competing for the same space. They serve complementary populations. HOPE reaches workers who can buy in high-value inner Sydney suburbs. Co-operative housing reaches everyone else — workers in outer Sydney, workers in regional communities, workers who will never own a home, and First Nations communities whose housing needs require culturally appropriate, community-controlled models.

E. What the data suggests

Three patterns emerge consistently across the evidence in Q1, Q2, and Q3.

The first is that the model works. Countries that have invested in co-operative housing over time have built systems where residents spend less of their income on housing. Victoria, starting from the same point as New South Wales, has twice the co-operative housing per capita today. The ARC-funded national research found co-operative housing members experience higher stability and security than people in all other forms of rental housing. The evidence base is not thin.

The second is that demand exists. HOPE Housing's waitlist of over 3,000 essential workers is a documented number, not a projection. The Anglicare data showing zero affordable listings in Northern Beaches and Sutherland on the days surveyed points to the same reality from a different angle. The people who would benefit from more co-operative housing are already visible in the data.

The third is that the sector is small relative to need — but the gap between New South Wales and Victoria shows that scale is not fixed. It reflects decisions made over time, and decisions can change.

What those observations mean for investment, and what form any response might take, is a question for the people with the authority to answer it.

5. Analysis of Data Quality, Data and Visual Ethics, and Unintended Data Harm

What this project is — and what it is not

This project combines Mercury's co-operative directory with public datasets on housing, aged care, employment, and community need. The goal is to help stakeholders see where co-operatives exist, where gaps are largest, and where opportunities may be strongest.

The findings are a starting point for conversation, not a final answer. Data can reveal patterns, but it cannot capture everything — the experiences of real people, the history of a community, or the practical barriers that do not show up in a spreadsheet.

How the data was cleaned

The Mercury dataset needed cleaning before use. Some organisations registered as housing co-operatives — such as ski lodges and clubs — were removed because they do not provide housing. For Persona 2, inclusive co-operatives were identified using organisation names and sector descriptions. Some relevant organisations may have been missed due to limited public information.

About "Michael"

Persona 3 uses the story of "Michael," a healthcare worker who commutes long distances because he cannot afford to live near his workplace. Michael is not a real person. He is a composite profile — a fictional character whose situation reflects patterns found across two real surveys: the Anglicare NSW Essential Workers Report (2025) and a HOPE Housing survey of 3,000 essential workers (2024). His story is used to make the data easier to understand, not to make claims about any specific individual.

Source: Gilbert, C., Nasreen, Z., & Gurran, N. (2023) for HOPE Housing — commute patterns and housing stress among essential workers · HOPE Housing survey of 3,000 essential workers (2024) — 56% considering leaving profession

About the 43% figure

The finding that 43% of rural aged-care services have no co-operative within 50km comes from the Mercury dataset. The analysis identified 261 residential aged-care services in rural and remote areas (Modified Monash Model categories

MM5 to MM7 — covering Small Rural through Very Remote). For each service, the distance to the nearest of 679 mapped co-operatives was calculated. 111 of the 261 services fall outside the 50km threshold — giving 43%.

This number shows where co-operative support is geographically absent. It does not measure how good or bad care is in those areas, and it does not account for workforce, funding, or other local factors.

About maps and distance

Several dashboards use distance to find nearby co-operatives or potential partners. Being close on a map does not guarantee collaboration. Real-world barriers — travel time, available resources, and local relationships — all matter. The maps show where opportunities may exist, not where partnerships will definitely happen.

About community disadvantage scores

SEIFA scores describe the general circumstances of an area, not the people or organisations in it. Areas with lower scores or fewer co-operatives should not be seen as weak or failing — they may simply reflect where investment has historically gone. These scores are used as a planning tool to identify where support could make the most difference.

About co-operative longevity

The survival comparisons in Persona 2 draw on BCCM and NME sector benchmarks, not on survival rates calculated from the Mercury dataset. The Mercury data supports these findings by showing the ages of co-operatives currently operating. These figures describe overall sector patterns — they do not predict whether any specific organisation will continue to operate.

About student support data

The MQ disability enrolment figures (2,183 in 2018 to 3,373 in 2024) come from MQ institutional data and are not independently verifiable through public QILT records. The student support satisfaction and teaching quality scores are drawn from publicly available QILT national reports. All figures reflect survey responses and may not represent every student's experience.

About international examples

The housing data from Sweden, Norway, and Austria shows what is possible when co-operative housing receives long-term government support. Each country has a different history, policy environment, and housing system. These examples are included to broaden perspective, not to suggest Australia should or could copy any single approach.

Responsible Use of Data

Throughout the project, care was taken to present information clearly and fairly. Simple chart designs were used to help users focus on the insights rather than visual effects, and visual choices were made to avoid exaggerating patterns or creating misleading impressions.

The project also recognises that data does not tell the whole story. Indicators such as disadvantage scores, social housing waitlists, and aged-care service gaps provide useful context, but they do not capture the strengths, experiences, and local knowledge within communities.

Most importantly, the dashboards are designed to support conversations and decision-making, not replace them. While data can reveal patterns and opportunities, meaningful decisions still require local knowledge, stakeholder input, and human judgement. The purpose of these dashboards is not to provide answers, but to help users ask better questions about where co-operatives can create the greatest impact.

6. Conclusion & Future Work

What the Three Personas Revealed

Although each persona explored a different challenge, they all led to the same conclusion: co-operatives are already working in many of the places where communities face housing pressures, service shortages, and workforce challenges, but their potential is often overlooked.

For **Peter**, the analysis showed that Australia's co-operative ecosystem is larger and more diverse than many people realise. The aged-care findings highlighted this clearly, with 43% of vulnerable rural services having no co-operative within 50km, revealing areas where stronger support and collaboration may be needed.

For **Min**, the data showed that Greater Sydney's co-operative sector could offer more than just placement opportunities. Many co-operatives are built around participation, inclusion, and community connection, making them potentially valuable environments for students seeking both professional experience and a sense of belonging.

For **Sarah**, the housing analysis showed that affordability challenges are not inevitable. Local and international examples suggest that co-operative housing can contribute to more stable, affordable, and community-focused housing outcomes when supported over time.

The Common Thread

Across all three personas, one pattern appeared consistently: the people and communities that could benefit most from co-operative models are often the least connected to them. The challenge is not that co-operatives do not exist, but that their opportunities, strengths, and potential impact are not always visible.

By bringing together co-operative locations, community needs, and supporting data in one place, the Co-op Map can help close the gap between where co-operatives are and where they would create the greatest impact. The three personas show that this gap is not random — it is concentrated in rural aged-care communities, disadvantaged student cohorts, and essential workers priced out of the areas they serve. These are not separate problems. They are the same structural gap, visible from three different angles.

Future Work

To remain useful over time, the platform will need regular updates to key datasets, particularly the Mercury directory, housing affordability data, and aged-care information.

Future versions could include additional layers such as public transport accessibility, regional workforce shortages, and local housing trends. Features that help users identify potential partners or collaboration opportunities could also transform the platform from a tool for exploration into a tool for action.

Most importantly, data can highlight patterns, but it cannot fully explain local needs or community priorities. Future work should therefore combine data analysis with conversations with co-operative members, community organisations, and local stakeholders to ensure that insights lead to meaningful and practical outcomes.

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